Most importantly, the technology push enabled Modi to consolidate his new image as a modern technocrat-administrator. This was not a pracharak with a closed shakha mindset, but a leader with an eye to the future. Tech geeks can be ideologically rigid and illiberal, but technology also symbolizes an egalitarian spirit based on merit and opportunity. Modi may have been twenty years older than Rahul, but technology helped him look and feel much younger. No surprise then that his highest ratings were often in the below-thirty age group.

The BJP has often been stereotyped as an ageing Hindu revivalist party which takes up potentially divisive issues like Ram mandir. The technology drive gave it a dramatically new avatar as a party that was holding out the dream of a 'digital democracy'—a nation of mouse, and not snake, charmers, as Modi put it. For a younger, aspirational India, this was just the kind of message of hope they wanted to hear from their leadership.

It was now a message that needed to be taken beyond the digital world. The advertising and media planners were ready to take Brand Modi to the next level.

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In the first week of February 2014, the advertising agency Ogilvy and Mather's (O&M) executive chairman and national creative director Piyush Pandey got a call that Narendra Modi wanted to meet him urgently. Pandey knew Modi from his 2010 Gujarat tourism advertising campaign which had featured Amitabh Bachchan and had been a huge success. He flew down to Gandhinagar for the meeting. Modi had a simple request: 'I want you to handle my advertising campaign. Only you can do this for me.'

Pandey, with his field marshal-style moustache was an iconic figure in the advertising industry, having won numerous awards. Modi's plea put him in in a slightly awkward position. He had turned down numerous offers to do political advertising in the past, including from Modi in the 2012 Gujarat elections and from the Congress as well. David Ogilvy, his guru, had advised against doing work for political parties in his seminal book on